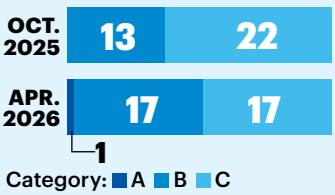
THE SCORECARD

How the 35 ranked FTOs fared across the two rounds



A+: 85% and higher

A: 70% to below **85%**

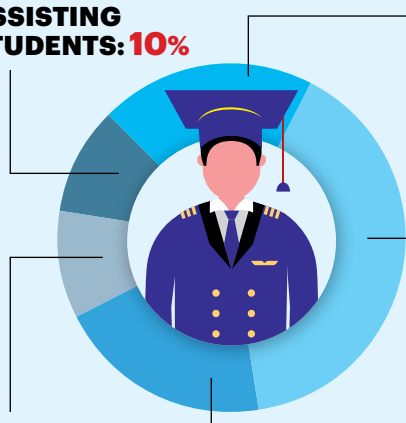
B: 50% to below **70%**

C: Less than **50%**

A C category triggers an official notice asking the school for an improvement plan

HOW THE RANKING WORKS

The DGCA ranks approved flying schools every six months across five areas of assessment



ASSISTING STUDENTS: 10%

PERFORMANCE: 20%
Criteria: Time students take to complete 175 flying hours, aircraft utilisation, percentage of students completing 175 hours

OPERATIONAL CAPABILITY: 40%
Criteria: Student-to-aircraft ratios, student-to-instructor ratios, maintenance staffing, number of aircraft, ground schools and simulators

REGULATORY COMPLIANCE: 10%

SAFETY: 20%

> **"To become a global aviation powerhouse, aviation training must be built on quality, safety and scale as well as a regulatory framework that encourages modern learning"**
>
> **MANOJ CHACKO,** *Founder and CEO, Fly91*



ing hours has risen from 32 to 50 per cent since the ranking was introduced.

THE DATA QUESTION

What the FTOs have an issue with is the integrity of data. "Wrong data can impact multiple parameters in the scoring process," says D.P. Hemanth, CEO, Asia Pacific Flight Training Academy, which has training bases in Hyderabad and Kalaburagi. "If you are taking wrong data—like our cadet count was taken as 180 or something, whereas our actual count is around 70—the number gets so skewed that, as a result, the aircraft-to-student ratio is skewed, which is 10 marks. The student-to-instructor ratio is skewed, which is another 10 marks, and so on. So, if you lose 20-30 marks out of a possible 80, it's a massive difference. Hence, it won't work."

AFTO president Harsh Singh points to an even stranger result. "My FTO has not been in operation for three and a half years," says the head of Redbird Flight Training Academy. "But even I was ranked 24, ahead of operational FTOs." When asked about it, a senior official says, "The ranking is applicable to all DGCA-approved FTOs that have completed 18 months as on February 28, 2026, from the date of approval." Chimes failed to improve its ranking from B across the two rounds, despite running the cadet pilot programme for India's largest airline, IndiGo. "We do not take this seriously anymore," says its CEO, Y.N. Sharma. "Despite several representations from us and others, the DGCA has refused to rectify the system, so the ranking has lost its credibility." AFTO's Singh is equally perplexed about Chimes. "If Chimes is grade B, are we to believe IndiGo will give the job to a sub-par flying school?" he asks.

The DGCA sources FTO data from the Electronic Governance for Civil Aviation (eGCA), the single-window platform designed to automate and streamline regulatory processes. But operators say the rankings have sometimes been based on data at variance with the platform. "You have to look at your own data, that's the least you can do," Sharma says. "I produce 60 cadets every year, for which I get 2,000 applications, so people can tell a good academy from a bad one, no matter what the rankings say."

The DGCA, however, denies there is any ambiguity about the data. They considered e-GCA information as on February 28, 2026, since the period of computation for the April 2026 rankings extended from March 1, 2025, to February 28, 2026. As for the allegation that there is no formal mechanism for FTOs to voice their objections and seek a review, a DGCA statement to INDIA TODAY says that the draft FTO ranking scorecard is shared with all FTOs, and their feedback taken into account while formulating the final ranking. The DGCA also says that it conducts sensitisation meetings with FTOs to invite comments and suggestions from time to time.

However, beyond the debate over data is an even more challenging question: should a regulator be generating a league table of organisations already compliant with its regulatory standards? "A regulator is ranking their own," says Hemanth. "Nowhere in the world does this happen." For the rankings to make a difference, the system itself will first have to pass a credibility test. ■